

1.4 MP3 Players

Audiophiles would balk at the idea of using portable MP3 players, what with their piddling earphones and the 128 kbps bitrate that are typically packed into them. But very few of us are true audiophiles!

The fact is, MP3 players are great for the daily commute. They're good for ambling around the place with music being piped into your ears. And if you can work while listening to music, you can mix business with pleasure, as it were, while in office. They can double up as backup storage devices. In general, they're fun accessories to have! You might want to shop around for better-quality earphones than those bundled with typical MP3 players, though—you just might find something that sounds way better.

Hard drive-based players offer larger capacities, but they can't stand jerks and such—you can't go jogging with a hard-disk based player strapped to your belt! Flash-based players are smaller, both in size and capacity. The good news is that they're improving in terms of storage space. Here, we mention the highlights of two Flash-based players and two hard-disk based players, the winners in our portable audio player comparison test in the May 2006 issue.

1.4.1 Flash-based

SAFA SF-Q100

- 1 GB capacity
- Great looks
- Record CDs directly without the need for a PC; voice recording
- 3D sound and equaliser functions; excellent sound quality
- 40 mW output power - quite good
- Colour 1-inch OLED display
- Lasts 17 to 20 hours on 2 AAA batteries
- Supports MPEG 1/2/2.5/3 Layer 3, WMA, ASF

